The plot, worth Rs 20.75 crore at the circle rate, was sold to West Bengal-based Jagatbandhu Tea Estate Pvt. Ltd for Rs 7 crore. According to the ED, a probe into the records of the circle office in Bargai, Ranchi, and the office of the Registrar of Assurances (Records), Kolkata, revealed that fake entries were inserted to falsify the original records pertaining to what was then defence land. The forgery was confirmed by the Directorate of Forensic Science Services in Gandhinagar.

As the ED dug deeper, it arrested seven people, including two government officials, Afshar Ali and Bhanu Partap Prasad. Prasad was the revenue sub-inspector with the Bargain circle office in Ranchi. Their confession exposed over a dozen land deals wherein Ranjan allegedly connived with them for the forging of deeds and documents, allowing illegal transfers of land. The ED has claimed to have seized incriminating evidence in the form of documents and digital devices during searches conducted in November-December 2022 and on April 24 and 26, 2023. The details suggest the existence of an organised group working in cahoots with land revenue officers, bureaucrats and politicians.

Though the Chota Nagpur Tenancy (CNT) Act and the Santhal Pargana Tenancy (SNT) Act protect the land rights of locals in Jharkhand, the state has witnessed multiple land scams. Scamsters there have targeted government land, selling off plots to unsuspecting buyers with the help of fake papers. Taking note of the practice, the Jharkhand revenue, registration and land reform department in 2020 had ordered the display of information boards on all government land. However, it seems to have had a limited effect in deterring the syndicate of land mafia, middlemen and bureaucrats. ■

BOOKS

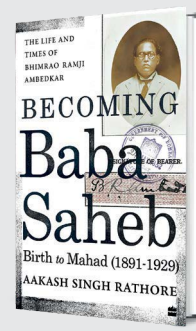
AN EXCEPTION

By Dinyar Patel

"I am not a part of the whole. I am a part apart." This declaration of B.R. Ambedkar, describing a Dalit's daily experience of ostracism and discrimination, rings throughout Ashok Gopal's new biography. It is a fitting metaphor for the man. Ambedkar was intellectually a part apart—a brilliant, innovative thinker unafraid of smashing idols to pieces. And, of course, he was a part apart in a deeply tragic way, as a lonely voice of a people subject to unspeakable horrors, a man who earned two doctorates but for whom the mere act of drinking from a common well could incite mob violence.

Gopal's book, the product of over 15 years of painstaking research, will be the standard-bearer for English-language biographies of Ambedkar. It has remarkable insights into Ambedkar's intellectual development. Here is a man who stocked 40,000 books in his personal library, who taught himself constitutional law by locking himself in his office for two weeks while receiving meals and Irani cafe chai through a window. Previous work on Ambedkar has pointed to the intellectual influence of John Dewey, his professor at Columbia University. Dewey is ever-present here, but Gopal demonstrates how Ambedkar innovated upon the ideas of a diverse range of other intellectuals, from Voltaire to Karl Marx.

Nearly seven decades after his death, Ambedkar's works still have the power to shock, disturb and shame. As Gopal notes about his own encounters with his oeuvre, "Ambedkar challenged almost every one of my preconceived notions about Indian society, culture, history and its well-known leaders." He asked tough questions.



BECOMING BABASAHEB (VOLUME 1): The Life and Times of Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar, Birth to Mahad (1891-1929)
by Aakash Singh Rathore
HARPERCOLLINS
₹699, 300 pages

A lively investigation of Ambedkar as a young man. Rathore's biography takes on his predecessors and finds them wanting, whether "lifeless anglophone biographies" or the canonical works of Dhananjay Keer and C.B. Khairmoday ("riddled with inaccuracies"). This book has stirred controversy for references to Ambedkar's romantic life, more of which, presumably in the next volume.